Data Readiness Checklist

DtrionGlobal

Get your data ready before analysis, reporting or forecasting

Tick each item as you go. Use this before you share data with an analyst, or before starting any reporting or forecasting project. It is a general guide, not advice for any specific legal or regulatory situation.

1. Define the goal

- [ ] Which decision or question should this data support?
- [ ] Who will use the result, and how often?
- [ ] What does "good enough" look like, and what is the deadline?

2. Inventory your sources

- [ ] List every file, system and export that holds relevant data.
- [ ] Note who owns each source and how data enters it (manual, import, API).
- [ ] Record the date range each source covers and any known gaps.

3. Check the basics

- [ ] Duplicate records identified.
- [ ] Missing values counted for each key column.
- [ ] Dates, units and currencies are consistent.
- [ ] Spellings and categories are consistent (for example, one name per customer).
- [ ] IDs that should be unique are unique.
- [ ] Outliers and obvious typos reviewed.
- [ ] Totals reconcile with the original source.

4. Agree the rules

- [ ] How to treat duplicates and missing values (keep, fill or exclude).
- [ ] Which source wins when two sources disagree.
- [ ] Written definitions for key metrics, such as revenue or active customer.
- [ ] Original files kept untouched; work done on copies.

5. Document

- [ ] A field dictionary: what each column means.
- [ ] Where each file came from and when it was exported.
- [ ] A log of every change made to the data.
- [ ] Known limitations of the data.

6. Protect

- [ ] Only the people who need the data have access.
- [ ] Data that is not needed for the task is removed or masked.
- [ ] Files are shared by secure means, not open links.

7. Plan the handover

- [ ] Agree the format of the deliverables (report, dashboard, dataset).
- [ ] Decide how often results need to be refreshed and by whom.
- [ ] Plan a review session so your team can use and maintain the result.

Not sure where to start? Share what you have with DtrionGlobal and we will tell you honestly what your data needs.